

What we need is an Anti-Patriarchy Day

International Women's Day is a day to celebrate women's achievements, but we'd like to start with a **provocative** statement: Should we reframe it as Anti-Patriarchy Day? While it is a day to see how far women have travelled, we believe it is a day to **examine** what holds us back, especially in terms of **systemic** challenges for growth. In our opinion, **patriarchy** represents the biggest systemic challenge.

Let's first clarify a definition of patriarchy. It is not about men vs women, as is often understood. It is about men and women, versus a system of holding power that is deeply unfair to women, where both men and women can be **complicit** in holding women back. Just like the term **feminism**, patriarchy is an **emotive** word, but we look at both through the lens of fairness and equality, not through the lens of men vs women.

Within this definition of patriarchy, we see two types: **Outright** patriarchy where women are visibly excluded from power or gain. For example, cases of sexual **harassment** or daughters being denied their fair share of **inheritance**. These are examples where there is little dispute that women are being wronged. Today, we would like to **spotlight** a **subtler** — yet equally **insidious** — form of patriarchy, which we would like to call **benign** patriarchy. This refers to situations wherein, in the **guise** of **compassion**, women's ambitions are **stifled** by those in more powerful positions.

For example, some years ago one of us (Aparna) wanted to write a book about her mental health condition but was told by her senior mental health professional that "she should not write, she should focus on supporting her husband's career or planning the children's summer holidays which she did so well". It was said **in the spirit of** compassion, as Aparna had **experienced** several **mood swings**, but it was **patronising** and deeply **upsetting**, as writing was a form of self-expression and **healing** for her.

Another common example is qualified and educated women who are not allowed to choose their profession but are told by their husbands' families that they can work only in the family business. Again, it **limits** their personal and professional growth. Women can be complicit in **imposing** benign patriarchy on those around them as well. Megha **encountered** the mother of a 15-year-old client who sent her daughter to a nutritionist, constantly **reiterating** that the daughter needs to be "thin and good-looking if she wants to be popular". This client was not **obese** nor had a health concern. The intention may be to be kind to someone who could be **vulnerable**, but benign patriarchy actually takes away the **kindness** that we have for each other, by being patronising and limiting to women.

This system also hurts men, as it forces them into a box of being the more powerful one. In private, men **often** express their unhappiness at not being allowed to show emotions or their frustration at being judged only by their professional performance. For women, the **tactical** solution to tackling benign patriarchy often **lies in** recognising that this is a power issue and that benign patriarchs are operating from their own contexts and what they **perceive** to be good intentions. As Robert Greene, author of The 48 Laws of Power writes, in situations where the opponent is more powerful, use the

surrender **tactic**: “Law 22. Transform weakness into power. Make surrender a tool of power... Save your hide for a later date when you can **reassert** your power. **Inwardly** you stay **firm**, but **outwardly** you bend... only appear to surrender.”

This is **precisely** what Aparna did. Although frustrated with her mental health professional, she continued seeing them, as she was dependent on their medical advice. However, she developed **allies** in her book club who supported her writing. When she felt stronger a few years later, she switched to a different practitioner who supported her writing and went on to publish a **memoir**. She continues to stay in touch with the original mental health professional, who now recognises her writing efforts and her new **persona** as a mental health **advocate**. The long-term solution is the recognition that benign patriarchy is a power struggle all around us, often those whom we trust the most. We need to call it out and engage with those in power to influence the way they think.

Benign patriarchy is so **subtle** that often we don't recognise it. This is exactly why we need a day to remind us of it: Anti-Patriarchy Day. On March 8 or any day of the year, because frankly, it happens all year around, everywhere.

Vocabulary

1. **Anti-Patriarchy** (noun) – A stance or movement against patriarchy, the system of society or government in which men hold the power and women are largely excluded from it. पितृसत्ता विरोधी
2. **Provocative** (adjective) – Incendiary, stimulating, instigative, challenging, confrontational उत्तेजक
3. **Examine** (verb) – Inspect, scrutinize, analyze, investigate, assess जांचना
4. **Systemic** (adjective) – Comprehensive, widespread, pervasive, extensive, across-the-board व्यापक
5. **Patriarchy** (noun) – A social system in which power is held by men, through cultural norms and customs that favor men over women. पितृसत्ता
6. **Complicit** (adjective) – Involved, collaborating, conniving, conspiring, colluding सहभागी
7. **Feminism** (noun) – The advocacy of women's rights on the ground of the equality of the sexes. नारीवाद
8. **Emotive** (adjective) – Emotional, moving, touching, stirring, poignant भावनात्मक
9. **Outright** (adjective) – Absolute, total, complete, unconditional, unequivocal स्पष्ट
10. **Harassment** (noun) – Aggressive pressure or intimidation. उत्पीड़न
11. **Inheritance** (noun) – Legacy, heritage, bequest, endowment, patrimony विरासत
12. **Spotlight** (verb) – Highlight, emphasize, underscore, feature, foreground प्रकाश में लाना
13. **Subtler** (noun) – More delicate or precise as to be difficult to analyze or describe. सूक्ष्मता
14. **Insidious** (adjective) – Stealthy, surreptitious, cunning, sneaky, treacherous धोखेबाज़
15. **Benign** (adjective) – Gentle, kindly, benevolent, friendly, amiable सौम्य
16. **Guise** (noun) – Appearance, semblance, facade, pretense, disguise रूप
17. **Compassion** (noun) – Sympathy, empathy, kindness, tenderness, mercy दया
18. **Stifle** (verb) – Suppress, smother, restrain, choke, strangle दबाना
19. **In the spirit of** (phrase) – With the intention or attitude of. के भावना में
20. **Experience** (verb) – Undergo, encounter, face, feel, live through अनुभव करना

21. **Mood swing** (noun) – An abrupt and apparently unaccountable change in mood. मूड में बदलाव
22. **Patronising** (adjective) – Condescending, disdainful, scornful, superior, dismissive अवहेलनापूर्ण
23. **Upsetting** (adjective) – Distressing, disturbing, troubling, disquieting, perturbing परेशान
24. **Healing** (noun) – Recovery, recuperation, rehabilitation, cure, restoration उपचार
25. **Limit** (verb) – Restrict, confine, constrain, cap, curtail सीमित करना
26. **Impose** (verb) – Enforce, apply, lay, establish, inflict थोपना
27. **Encounter** (verb) – Meet, come across, face, run into, confront सामना करना
28. **Reiterate** (verb) – Repeat, restate, recapitulate, echo, reaffirm दोहराना
29. **Obese** (adjective) – Overweight, fat, heavy, corpulent, bulky मोटा
30. **Vulnerable** (adjective) – At risk, in danger, unprotected, susceptible, exposed असुरक्षित
31. **Kindness** (noun) – Generosity, benevolence, charity, goodwill, compassion दयालुता
32. **Often** (adverb) – Frequently, regularly, commonly, repeatedly, habitually अक्सर
33. **Tactical** (adjective) – Strategic, planned, calculated, deliberate, scheming युक्तिसंगत
34. **Lie in** (verb) – Consist, reside, exist, dwell, be found in में स्थित है
35. **Perceive** (verb) – Discern, recognize, notice, see, become aware of समझना
36. **Tactic** (noun) – Strategy, plan, scheme, maneuver, approach रणनीति
37. **Reassert** (verb) – Affirm again, restate, reaffirm, declare again, reiterate पुनः स्थापित करना
38. **Inwardly** (adverb) – Internally, inside, within, in one's mind, secretly आंतरिक रूप से
39. **Firm** (adjective) – Steadfast, resolute, unwavering, solid, stable मजबूत
40. **Outwardly** (adverb) – Externally, on the outside, superficially, apparently, ostensibly बाह्य रूप से
41. **Precisely** (adverb) – Exactly, accurately, correctly, just, squarely सटीक रूप से
42. **Ally** (noun) – Supporter, friend, confederate, accomplice, partner सहयोगी

43. **Memoir** (noun) – Autobiography, diary, journal, record, account जीवनी

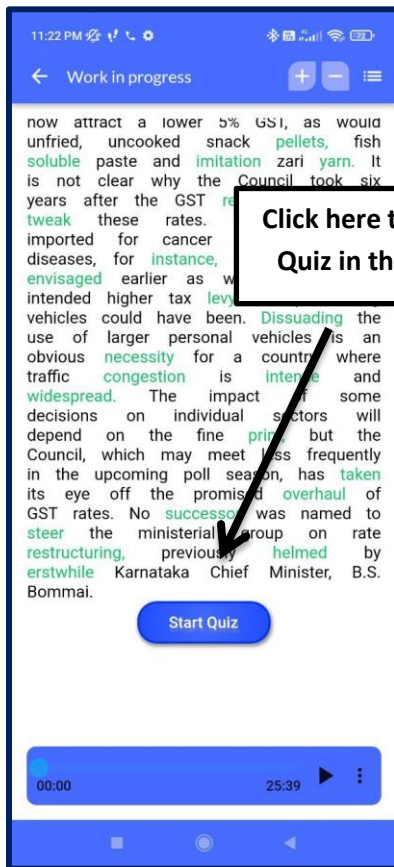
44. **Persona** (noun) – Image, identity, personality, character, role व्यक्तित्व

45. **Advocate** (noun) – Supporter, proponent, champion, promoter, defender समर्थक

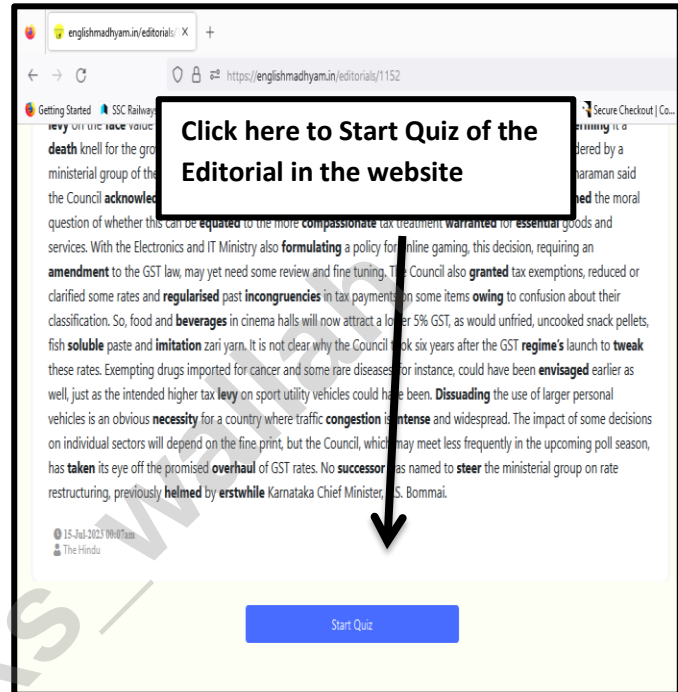
46. **Subtle** (adjective) – Delicate, fine, nuanced, understated, refined सूक्ष्म

@mocks_wallah

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



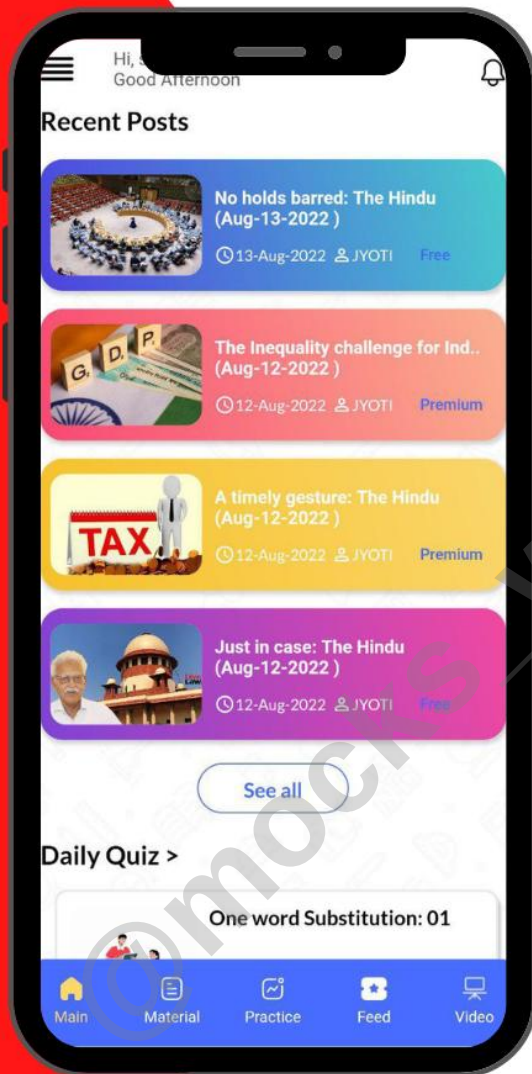
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